The symbol for "om"—*life force—is used by followers of the Indian practice of Ayurveda as a focus for meditation.*

in the Western tradition, Hippocrates writes about "*vis medicatrix naturae*" or the healing power of nature, while modern Western medical herbalists and homeopaths use the term "vital force." The importance of the vital force was diminished in the West by the philosophy of René Descartes (1596–1650). This French mathematician divided the world into body and mind, nature and ideas. His philosophy ordained that the intangible vital force that maintains life and governs good health was the province of religion rather than of the newly self-aware "science" of medicine. To the new medical establishment, inching its way forward toward scientifically sound medical practices, "supernatural" concepts such as the vital force were a reminder of the ignorance and superstition that were part and parcel of older healing practices.

Even before Descartes' theories, the rational approach to scientific and medical exploration was beginning to reap rewards. Slowly, medical understanding of bodily functions was gaining ground. William Harvey (1578–1657) made a detailed study of the heart and circulation, proving for the first time that, contrary to Galenic thought, the heart pumped blood around the body. Published in 1628, his study is a classic example of the revolution in medical science.

Since Harvey's time, science has had astounding success in revealing how the body works on a biochemical level and in distinguishing different disease processes. However, by comparison it has been altogether less successful in developing effective medical treatments for the relief and cure of diseases.

The Gap in the Scientific Approach

In hindsight, it seems as if the new science of medicine could only be born in separation from the traditional arts of healing, with which it had always been intertwined. As a result, even though traditional medicine has generally lacked scientific explanation, it has frequently been far ahead of medical science in the way it has been applied therapeutically. In *American Indian Medicine* (University of Oklahoma Press, 1970), Virgil Vogel provides a good example of "ignorant" folk medicine outstripping scientific understanding in therapeutic application:

"During the bitter cold winter of 1535–6, the three ships of Jacques Cartier were frozen fast in the fathom-deep ice of the St Lawrence River near the site of Montreal. Isolated by four feet of snow, the company of 110 men subsisted on the fare stored in the holds of their ships. Soon scurvy was so rampant among them that by mid-March, 25 men had died and the others, 'only three or foure excepted,' were so ill that hope for their recovery was abandoned. As the crisis deepened Cartier had the good fortune to encounter once again the local Indian chief, Domagaia, who had cured himself of the same disease with 'the juice and sappe of a certain tree'. The Indian women gathered branches of the magical tree, 'boiling the bark and leaves for a decoction, and placing the dregs upon the legs.' All those so treated rapidly recovered their health, and the Frenchmen marvelled at the curative skill of the natives."

Naturally, the Native Americans had not heard of vitamin C deficiency, which causes scurvy, nor would they have been able to explain in rational terms why the treatment worked. Indeed, it was not until 1753 that James Lind (1716–1794), a British naval surgeon, inspired partly by Cartier's account, published *A Treatise of the Scurvy*, which showed conclusively that the disease could be prevented by eating fresh greens, vegetables, and fruit, and was caused by their lack in the diet. James Lind's work is a marvellous example of what can be achieved by combining a systematic and scientific approach with traditional herbal knowledge.

Mask of a northwestern Native American shaman. *The efficacy of techniques used by native healers often surpassed that of conventional medical practices of the time.*